Relative Pronouns – I

Relative Pronouns

- Link a main clause to a dependent clause.
- This pronoun introduces the dependent clause that describes someone or something mentioned in the main clause.
- The person or thing the pronoun refers to is called the **antecedent**.
- A relative clause may serve as a subject, a direct object, or an object of a preposition.

Two independent sentences:
Il va acheter **la maison**. Je veux vendre **la maison**.

A complex sentence with relative pronoun que connecting main clause and a dependent clause:
Il va acheter la maison **que** je veux vendre.

Choosing the correct relative pronoun depends on the role it plays for the dependent clause: Subject, Direct Object, Indirect Object etc.

Que (Whom/Which)

Acts as a direct object for the dependent clause and can **refer to both people and things**.

- Note that **que** becomes **qu'** before a vowel.
- Que is always followed by a subject.

Français	English
Les voitures **qu'**il vend sont chères.	The cars (**which/that**) he sells are expensive.
Je n'aime pas le livre **que** vous avez acheté hier.	I don't like the book **that** you bought yesterday.
Je connais l'homme **que** vous avez rencontré hier.	I know the man **whom** you met yesterday.
Qui est le garçon **qu'**elle embrasse ?	Who is the boy **whom** she is kissing?

Note: In compound tenses, if the direct object is placed before the helping verb, the past participle agrees in gender and number with that direct object.

Français	English
Dis-moi le nom de **la fille** que nous avons **rencontrée** hier soir.	Tell me the name of the girl (**whom**) we met last night.
J'ai contacté **la dentiste** que tu as **recommandée**.	I contacted the dentist (**whom/that**) you recommended.

Qui (Who, Which, That)

The relative pronoun "qui" **acts as a subject** for the dependent clause. Qui **may refer to people or things** and translates to **who, which, or that**.

- Note that the -i of qui is never dropped in front of a vowel sound.
- Qui as a relative pronoun is followed by a verb in a dependent clause.
- The verb in the dependent clause is conjugated according to the antecedent (the actual subject) referred to by qui.

Français	English
Je préfère **les romans qui finissent** bien.	I prefer **novels which** end well.
Il adore **les restaurants qui servent** de la cuisine italienne.	He loves **the restaurants which** serve Italian food.
La personne qui vient de parler est mon oncle.	**The person who** just spoke is my uncle.

Note: When *qui* is the subject of the dependent clause, the verb following *qui* agrees with the antecedent that *qui* replaces.

Français	English
Il aime les **histoires** qui **finissent** bien.	He likes stories (**which/that**) end well.
C'est **toi** qui **es** responsable. C'est **vous** qui **êtes** responsable.	You are the one **who** is responsible.
C'est **moi** qui **me suis marié(e)** hier soir.	It's me **who** got married last night.

Où (When, Where)

Où **refers to an antecedent in the main clause**, which is either a noun of place or time. Où thus **acts as an adverb of time or place** for the dependent clause.

Français	English
Avril est **le mois où** la plupart des gens partent en vacances.	April is **the month when** most people go on a vacation.
La ville où j'habite est très tranquille.	**The city where** I live is very peaceful.
C'est **l'endroit où** je l'ai rencontrée.	This is **the place where** I met her.
Je me souviens encore **du jour où** je me suis divorcé.	I still remember **the day when** I got divorced.

Difference Between "Où" and "Quand"

An antecedent (the moment in time) is specified in the main clause when we use the relative pronoun **où** (when). That is not the case with the subordinate conjunction **quand** (when).

Où	Quand
Je me souviens encore **du jour où** je l'ai rencontrée. I still remember **the day when** I met her.	Elle était endormie **quand** je suis revenue. She was asleep **when** I came back.
Le moment où il a gagné le match, tout le monde était content. **The moment when** he won the match everyone was happy.	Tout le monde était content **quand** il a gagné le match. Everyone was happy **when** he won the match.

Prepositions + Relative Pronouns

When verbs are followed by prepositions, the relative pronouns **qui**, **quoi**, **lequel**, **laquelle**, **lesquels** and **lesquelles** are used.

Preposition + Qui (For/With/Without Whom)

It refers to **an indirect object** antecedent which follows prepositions, except for the preposition **"de"**. Since qui here is referring to an indirect object, it is followed by a subject in the dependent clause *unlike the simple relative pronoun **"qui"** which acts as a subject for the dependent clause.

Prepositions + Qui as a relative pronoun is used only while referring to people.

Français	English
J'aimerais savoir **à qui** appartient cette voiture.	I'd like to know **to whom** this car belongs.
Kaustubh est le cousin **avec qui** je parle souvent.	Kaustubh is the cousin **with whom** I speak often.
Je sais **à qui** vous ressemblez.	I know **to whom** you resemble.
Ivana est la femme **sans qui** je ne peux pas vivre.	Ivana is the woman **without whom** I can't live.

Preposition + Quoi (In/With/For/Without What)

It refers to **an indirect object** antecedent which follows prepositions, except for the preposition **"de"**. Since quoi here is referring to an indirect object, it is followed by a subject in the dependent clause.

Français	English
Il ne sait pas **à quoi** elle s'intéresse.	He doesn't know **what** she is interested **in**.
Il faut savoir **pour quoi** on investit son temps.	One must know **what** they are using their time **for**.
Je ne comprends pas **avec quoi** le porter.	I don't know **what** to wear it **with**.